TRIDENT CLUSTERS

Facing our traditional adversaries and the Indian Ocean Region, the three theatre commands have us covered

PAKISTAN-CENTRIC WESTERN THEATRE COMMAND

From Indira Col on Saltoro Ridge in the Siachen Glacier to Gujarat

HQ in Jaipur

MARITIME COMMAND

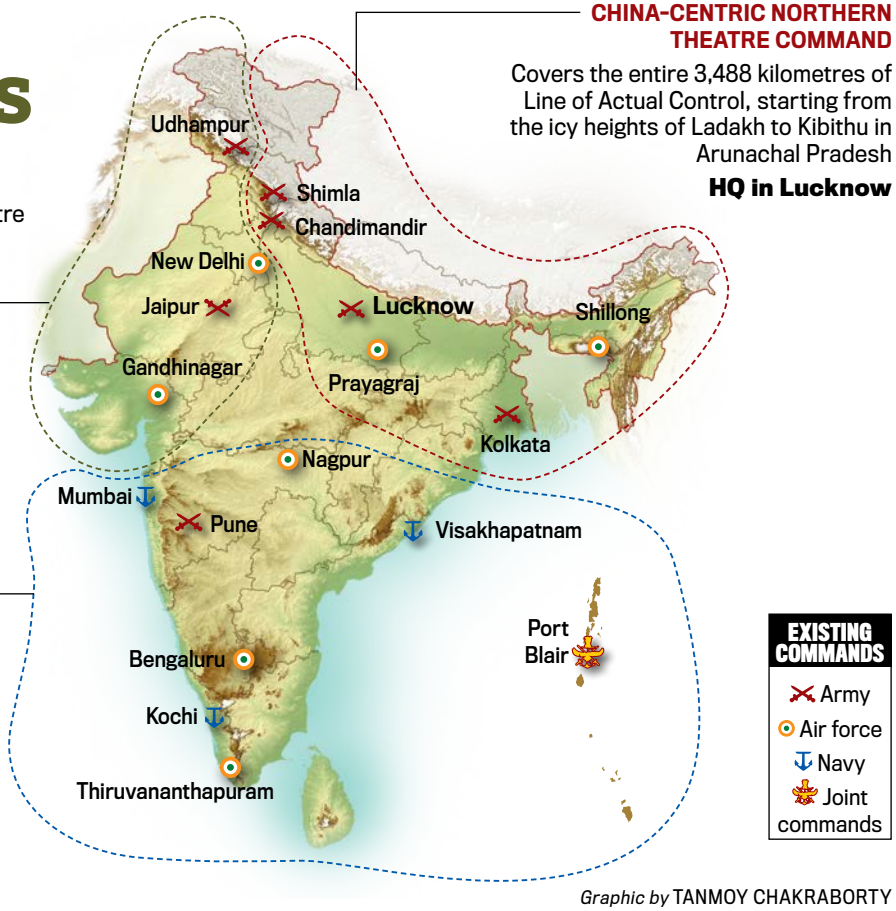
Responsible for India's coastline of 7,516 km, as well as the Indian Ocean Region

HQ in Karwar, Karnataka

CHINA-CENTRIC NORTHERN THEATRE COMMAND

Covers the entire 3,488 kilometres of Line of Actual Control, starting from the icy heights of Ladakh to Kibithu in Arunachal Pradesh

HQ in Lucknow



Graphic by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY

The Perils in the Journey

There are immense challenges to creating theatre commands. Foremost among them, experts believe, are inadequate intra- and inter-service integration of communications and networks; the paucity of overall resources, in particular air assets, long-range artillery and missiles; non-availability of commanders and staff trained in joint services environments; inadequately mature intelligence structures and a nascent defence industry. The issue of command and control, including the chain of operational command, is yet to be fine-tuned, and the chain for politico-military guidance has yet to be formalised. These aspects need to be resolved before creating integrated military theatre commands.

"The process must be implemented in a phased manner, putting the building blocks in place and test-bedding the structures. Also, it's not too late to evolve a base vision document and a roadmap," says Lt Gen. Ahuja. Officers say that breaking out of service alignment is not easy when all three services have different cultures of functioning. Lt Gen. Sharma points out that at the existing command level, operation and administrative verticals will have to be split between the services involved. This, he says, will be difficult.

The original challenge against the very idea of theatre commands came from sections of the services, which were not on the same page on the matter. However, CDS Anil Chauhan, who has been in office for 10 months now, has managed to iron out the differences between them.

For example, the IAF was vehemently opposed to the proposed creation of an Air Defence Command, claiming that a majority of its inventory comprised multi-role aircraft like the Mirages, MiG 29s, Sukhois and even the newly-inducted Rafales, which were ideal for offensive action too, not just a defensive one. It argued that such a command would divide limited resources between that and the other commands, and pointed out the folly of using multi-role fighters for solely defence or ground attack roles. Gen. Chauhan's plan has done away with the Air Defence Command altogether. Individual IAF commands will now join the theatre commands according to their locations. It is believed that the army and IAF will hold the top posts of the Northern and Western theatre commands in rotation. The navy will retain the maritime theatre for itself.

As of now, Gen. Chauhan is giving the final touches to the theatrisation proposal before sending it to defence minister Rajnath Singh. Once approved, the plan will have to get a final nod from the Cabinet Committee on Security. South Block officials assess that theatre commands will get off the ground in 12 to 15 months from now. ■